

Forward plan background (bring-up-to-speed)

Canonical name: `04_Project_story_plain_English.md`
Original archive: `obsolete/original_filenames/forward_plan_background.md`
Date: 2026-06-15 (PD12 ladder patch 12:00)
From: COMPASS
To: Charles Levine
Status: Temporary reader’s guide — you do not need to read Round 1–5 correspondence files to move forward.
Reading order + glossary: `01_forward_plan_reading_guide.md` — start with “Symbol systems” and “B-lite closure” if Rung / Path II / `S` lose you
Print stack: `Charles_reading_list.md`
Pivotal insights (nuggets): `13_INSIGHT_NUGGETS.md` — cross-project framing worth keeping
Canonical action doc: `20260615_1045_COMPASS_to_Charles_forward_plan_and_questions.md`
PD12 reassessment: `14_PD12_reassessment_memo.md` — read **after** action doc + PD12 guidance (optional; see reading guide)

What you were trying to do

You felt **lost in the sauce** — too many threads (Army, basketball, tenure, generative model, predictions, Wang, planner queues, etc.). You ran an **agent correspondence experiment**: route questions, have agents reply in `3-Master_Plan/`, keep going until everyone agreed on the science and was **waiting on you**, not on each other.
That worked. The experiment is **complete**. The output you actually need is the forward plan doc linked above. This file is the plain-English version of that plus the rounds.

The one sentence version

You have a cross-domain empirical finding, a candidate minimal mechanism, two named predictions, and a claim table — and the only blockers now are your locks, SCOUT packaging one export folder, and VECTOR writing the paper.

The scientific story (what everyone agreed on)

1. The finding (Tier 1 — done)

Across very different systems, **how good your local peer pool is** relates to **advancement** in a **nonlinear** way: modest pools can help, very elite pools can hurt (inverted-U with an elite-tier dip).

Setting	Status
Army	Strong — mature empirical work
Basketball	Strong — replicated
Tenure	Preliminary — stage 9 figure is OK for draft with honest limitations

2. The minimal mechanism (Tier 2 — close enough to write)

Not a huge realistic simulation of everything. The **minimal** story:

*Advancement propensity $\approx$ **Ability** – **Congestion** (with soft assignment / finite slots).
Talent-only selection **fails** — it cannot produce the inverted-U story by itself.*

Path II (locked): Basketball runs a small **generative proof-of-concept** on this. Army and tenure do **not** need matching generative sims for v1. Army and tenure are **empirical legs** at different maturity.
Important honesty: The generative POC is demonstrated on **pool mean**, not a bin-for-bin replay of the **LOO pool quality** empirical axis. That is **not** a blocker — it must be stated clearly in the paper.

2.5. Model-guided empirical features (Rung 2.5 — PD12 Priority 3)

Alex’s May 20 guidance: the theory should **propose new measurements**, not only fit old curves.

Construct	Basketball	Army	Tenure
Team quality $\bar{a}_t$	<code>poolq_loo</code>	Pool minus mean	<code>poolq_loo_mean</code>
Congestion $C_{i,t}$	<code>crowding_smooth</code>	Pool size / $\wedge$ hook (prose)	<code>pool_size_oa_loo</code> (on panel)

Status: Mostly **already built** in SCOUT pipeline. D10 exports + staging `#12` §3 (Methods) make this stage explicit — **not** a new workflow.

3. Predictions (Tier 3 — named, not all fully tested)

Wang move: the model should predict something you **did not** use to find the curve — and predictions should **test** the model-guided measurements (especially quality vs congestion).

#	Prediction	Where it lives
#1	Near-threshold heterogeneity — elite-pool dip strongest for borderline performers	SCOUT has basketball export; Army can support analogously
#2	Peak shift with global Λ (distinction / slot capacity)	Army-led prose ; conceptual hook, no finished Λ-sweep figure in repo yet

Mean $\times$ dispersion, networks, full deconstruction — **deferred**.

4. The paper (Tier 4 — next)

Wang structure (PD12-aligned): phenomenon → minimal mechanism → **model-guided features** → predictions → limitations.

- **Paper first**, dissertation packaging second
- **Dakota v03** = section spine
- VECTOR filed a **claim language table** — what you may and may not say (supported / preliminary / unsupported)

What happened in Rounds 1–5 (you can skip the files)

Round	What happened
1	Inventory: Jun 11 COMPASS→agent Q&A all answered. First cross-agent pings. Gap: SCOUT closure checklist missing.
2	SCOUT filed minimal model closure (green/yellow/red checklist). PEER/CODA supplied cross-domain rows. VECTOR still owed claim table.
3	VECTOR filed claim language table + M1–M5 sign-off (no agent conflicts). Everyone aligned on Path II.
4	Status round — nothing new on disk; waiting on you + VECTOR STANDING BY.
5	STANDING BY protocol: each agent lists final questions for you only . All five filed.
After	COMPASS merged everything into the forward plan doc.

Reading strategy the agents validated: Rounds 1–2 needed full-folder reads; after that, **hub + delta** was enough. You only need the **forward plan** unless you want forensic detail.

What each agent is doing now

Agent	Status	Waiting on you for
CODA (Army)	STANDING BY	AWS figure list, Alex (estimand, TB-stratify), optional Λ stub yes/no
PEER (Tenure)	STANDING BY	C1–C2 (OpenAlex tier + CSV names)
SCOUT (Basketball)	STANDING BY	D10 go + bundle folder path
VECTOR (Manuscript)	STANDING BY	Confirm manuscript priority; draft after D10 + C1–C2
COMPASS	Done synthesizing	Your Tier 1 answers

No agent is waiting on another agent for science or planning.

Jargon cheat sheet

Term	Plain English
D10	SCOUT packages manuscript artifacts into one folder (figures, axis table, score one-pager, manifest) — ~1–2 sessions, no new science
M4	“Any fights left between agents?” VECTOR said no
Path II	Empirical U on LOO axis + basketball generative POC on pool mean + honest axis mismatch
Layer B	Tenure Cox cells (10–12) — pre-submission , not draft blocker
C1–C2	Tenure inference policy: which OpenAlex tiers, which CSV filenames
Claim table	VECTOR’s cheat sheet for what the manuscript may claim

What you should do next (minimal path)

You do **not** need to read 60 files. Tier 1 answers are filed in `02_Charles_decisions_locked.md` (original batch was obsolete forward plan §6–§7).

1. **Q-SCOUT-9** — bundle path → default `datasets/mbb/exports_inverted_u_v0/scout_manuscript_v1/`
2. **Q-D10** — **go** on SCOUT export bundle
3. **C1** — HIGH + MEDIUM OpenAlex for tenure inference
4. **C2** — `R1_tenure_data.csv` + `faculty_panel_inference_v1.csv`
5. **C12–C13, V1–V3** — confirm predictions, outline, manuscript-first focus

6. Q-DEFAULTS — “use agent defaults” for softer Tier 2 items

Then:

```
SCOUT → build D10 bundle
PEER → inference CSV after C1–C2
VECTOR → ink manuscript per `#10` (locked first pass: **manuscript §5 → §1 → §4**)
You → schedule Alex for Army estimand + TB-stratify (Tier 3)
```

What you can safely ignore until later

- 525 / UIC work (tabled)
- Pool-size audit (pre-publication)
- Tenure Layer B Cox (pre-submission)
- Generative LOO bin-for-bin match
- Network extensions, assortativity as primary prediction
- Canonical Army figure filenames (until AWS sync)
- Most Round 1–5 ping files (archaeology only)

If you read only a few more files

Full order: see [Charles_reading_list.md](#) (must-read #1–#6).

Optional deep history (not required for inking):

1. [Forward plan questions](#) — superseded by [02_Charles_decisions_locked.md](#)
2. [PD12 guidance](#) — Alex’s four priorities
3. [PD12 reassessment](#) — ladder relabel
4. [Claim guardrails](#) — §F “Do Say / Do Not Say” (subsection of [#07](#), not manuscript §F)
5. [Generative closure](#) — SCOUT C1–C8

The center of gravity

```
Phenomenon → Minimal model → Model-guided features → Prediction → Paper
```

PD12 what we deliver in v1: Priority 3 (congestion / model-guided features) + partial Priority 2 (talent-only fail).

PD12 what we defer (say so to Alex): Priority 1 (3-domain identifiability), Priority 4 (fourth-domain falsification).

The planner and rounds were **coordination**, not new science. The science was already moving; you needed a **shared stop rule** and **one ordered question list for you**. The June 15 PD12 reassessment adds **explicit middle rungs** so the plan matches Alex’s progression without expanding scope.

Temporary background doc. Delete or archive when no longer needed.